

Singh stopped it flawlessly, and Aslam's hockey stick swung in a perfect arc, sending the ball to the right of the Malaysian goalkeeper, who was caught on the wrong foot. A deathly silence gripped the stadium as India survived. In extra time, Harcharan Singh scored, and India reached the final.

Back home, we were glued to our radio sets. Ace commentator Jasdev Singh was on air, and we missed nothing. His words painted the scene for us. India trailed after an early goal, but Surjit Singh equalised, and Ashok netted the match-winner — his most precious contribution to Indian hockey. India's goals came in

the second half. We had the new poster boys of Indian sport. Hockey was the game to watch. The team returned to a hero's welcome. As reported in *The Hindu*, "The high and low of Madras rubbed shoulders with one another in acclaiming the achievement of Ajitpal and his men in winning the World Cup at Kuala Lumpur. India's hockey heroes were taken in a procession from Anna Statue in Anna Salai (Mount Road) to Hotel Woodlands, where a reception was held for them."

Amidst the celebrations, the Indian team was charged duty fees at the airport for electronic goods they had received as gifts after their

Kuala Lumpur triumph. It was an embarrassment, but timely intervention by IHF president M.A.M. Ramaswamy saved them. He brought it to the notice of then Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, who ordered an immediate waiver. "The customs officials came to the hotel to reimburse the duty fees they had charged us," said Diwan.

Sadly, the euphoria of the 1975 World Cup faded in Montreal the following year when India returned home without an Olympic medal for the first time. The switch to artificial turf wiped out the glory attained on natural grass. "We are still chasing an international gold," lamented Aslam.

Leslie Fernandez

It feels great that we are still being honoured and felicitated by people across India.

At the same time, I feel sad that some of our 1975 World Cup-winning team members are no longer with us.

However, it is heartening that we have a World Cup group on WhatsApp where we stay in touch.

Nobody expected us to win the World Cup. There were no practice matches, and in the months leading up to the tournament, there was no proper national federation, as infighting was rife. The Indian Olympic Association was running the show at the time. Ramaswamy became the president of the Indian Hockey Federation during the World Cup.

The victory was undoubtedly sweet, and we were treated royally upon our return home. Our 1975 World Cup-winning team played exhibition matches against the 'Rest of India' in Delhi, Lucknow, Punjab, and Chennai.

Nothing can match the feeling of winning the World Cup and the manner in which people back home welcomed us.

As told to K. Keerthivasan



B. P. Govinda

In those days, people used to talk about the 1983 Cricket World Cup triumph of the Indian team, where Kapil Dev and Sunil Gavaskar were — and still are — household names.

Our 1975 Hockey World Cup victory is equally great, as no other hockey team from our country has won the Cup since.

I believe this is a huge achievement and highlights how tough it is to win the World Cup.

Now, it feels wonderful to be invited to various functions.

Recently, Hockey India honoured the 11 surviving members with cash awards. In 2024, the organising committee of the Surjit Singh Memorial Hockey Tournament also honoured all the team members of the 1975 World Cup with cash awards.

In fact, Surjit Singh was one of our teammates in the 1975 triumph. Unfortunately, he died in an accident.

Then, on April 19, the Chhattisgarh Government promised to honour us.

It is a happy feeling to realise that we are still recognised.

As told to K. Keerthivasan